# Ideakutir

## Designing a Portfolio You Can Get Lost In

An experimental portfolio that transforms professional work into a navigable house, exploring the tension between discoverability, spatial storytelling, and the unsettling feeling of being watched by a space that knows too much.

by Ashani Gorakhnath

## Why is a design portfolio?

It's a universal experience amongst designers to dread the inevitable: **I have to update my design portfolio.**

Somewhere between the designer memes, the increasingly elaborate excuses, and the sudden urge to learn an entirely new software instead of opening that old case study, updating a portfolio becomes a genre of its own. Every designer knows the ritual: you look at your old work, cringe a little, question whether any of it is worth showing, and then discover that the work of presenting the work is somehow more difficult than the work itself.

you can't be a bad designer if you don't update your portfolio

Does he bite?
No, but he can hurt you in other ways
You will never finish your portfolio

Part of it is a familiar anxiety that my work isn't good enough to showcase. Another part is figuring out what, exactly, I'm supposed to showcase. My practice has never been particularly obedient to neat categories. I move between disciplines, mediums, questions, and ways of making. Some projects become polished outcomes; others remain experiments, fragments, research trails, or things I haven't quite figured out how to explain yet.

I have spent considerable amount of time going over my projects, trying to find themes, connections, that would help me organise them into the clean, labelled and tagged projects. Portfolios tend to reward coherence. They ask for a recognisable professional identity, a clear specialisation, a carefully edited selection of outcomes. They want the finished object, preferably accompanied by a compelling process diagram and a measurable impact statement.

As I sat there, avoiding eye-contact with a blank figma files daring me to name it "Portfolio 2026", my eyes went over my current space. A small college student apartment in Bangalore, with bare minimum furnishing, a 2bhk designed to be rented out to broke grad students who would take anything...my washbasin is the size IRCTC would approve of. In a bout of homesickness I think my space back home, walls full of my artworks over the years, shoes I designed tucked away on the rack, a metal-cast mirror I hand sculpted for my graduation project back in 2017, a figurine of me as a detective I got from India Today for my work on CrimeTak, other cherished knick-kancks and tchotchkes.

I found myself visualising my portfolio as a space to put my tchotchkes(projects) . After all a portfolio is a space we prepare for other people to enter. We decide what belongs on display, what stays hidden, what gets discarded, and what version of ourselves the arrangement is meant to communicate.

This became the starting point for **Ideakutir**: an attempt to make a portfolio that doesn't just display my work, but gives visitors a way to move through the many things that make up my practice. Perhaps the portfolio will never really be finished. Perhaps the more interesting question is what kind of space it could become while I'm still figuring it out.

## Research & refrences

:(
@itsoverkitten
Follow

I love your niche references! Are you typically ignored in large groups by any chance?

22:28 · 06/06/2025 · **3.7M** Views

463 27K 229K 12K

**The references are bigger on the inside**

I find myself back on the similar struggle of having to categorise my references. Not all of them are peer-reviewed academic papers, or a designer's whose approach inspired mine. Inspiration comes from the latent tendencies of pattern-recognisition, from a tab in my mind somewhere that connected to this new tab I just opened.

For this project, the starting point would be this video eassay by youtuber Jacob Geller, Control, Anatomy, and the Legacy of the Haunted House. I stumbled upon it while rabbitholing about haunted houses in media few years ago, and it is a tab that stays open.

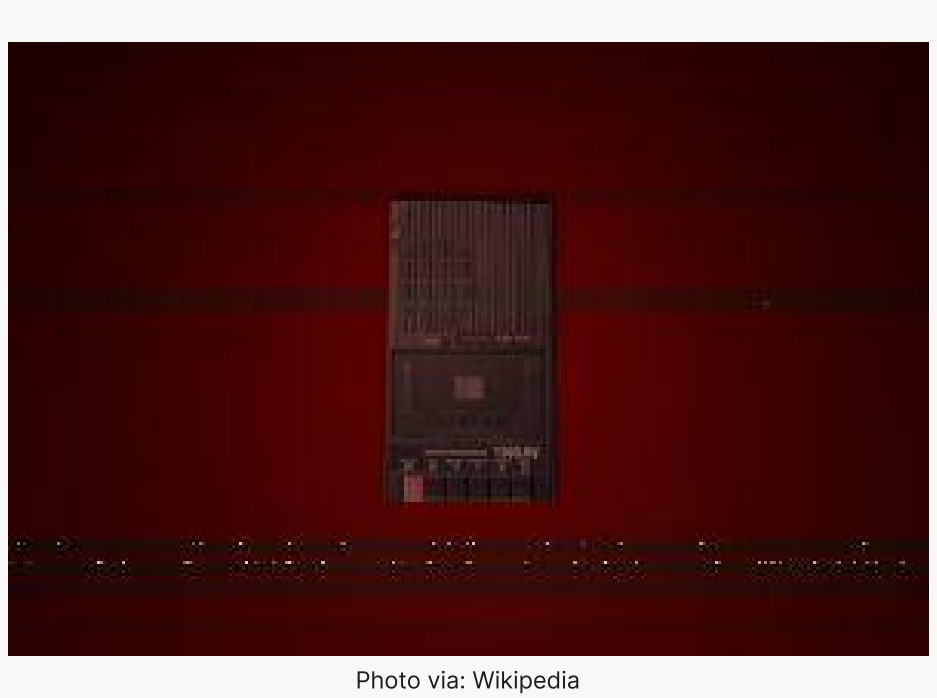


Photo via: Wikipedia

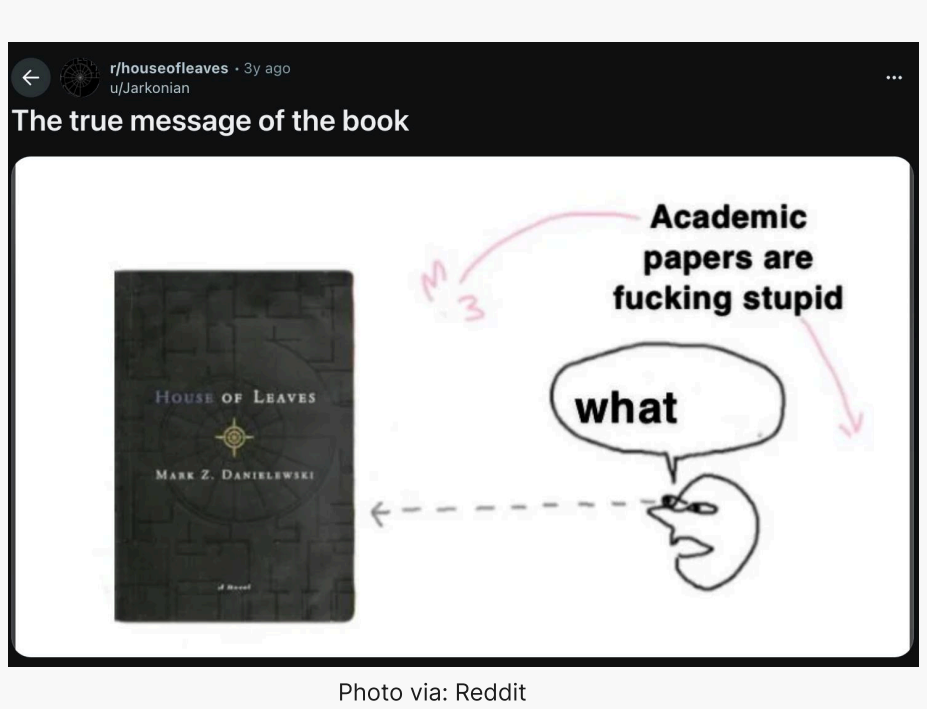

r/houseofleaves · 3y ago
u/Jarkonian
The true message of the book

Photo via: Reddit

**A house not a home**

The video essay introduced me to **Kitty Horrorshow's Anatomy** and **Mark Z. Danielewski's House of Leaves,** two works that became major reference points for **Ideakutir.** I was drawn to this concept of a space that reveals itself through exploration rather than explanation. Both of these works defy the concep tof a house being a passive container. Architecture becomes something to be experienced, explored, and questioned. Familiar spaces begin to feel unfamiliar; corridors, rooms, and thresholds become part of the narrative rather than simply places to move through. Both Anatomy and House of Leaves play with the unsettling possibility that a house cannot be fully mapped or understood, no matter how closely you examine it.

I borrow from this sense of spatial uncertainty to imagine a portfolio that is not simply a collection of neatly organised projects, but a place to wander through. While the original works use the house to evoke dread and instability, **Ideakutir** adapts these ideas to explore the messiness of a creative practice: its different rooms of interest, unexpected connections, unfinished corners, and the things that only reveal themselves if you take the time to look.

Perhaps this was a more honest model for my portfolio than the conventional grid of projects and case studies. A house could hold different parts of my practice without forcing them into a single category. Its rooms could have distinct identities, its corridors could connect seemingly unrelated things, and its objects could reveal projects, interests, and fragments of a larger story.

Obligatory misalligned line of text with a meta context

## Business in the front, haunting in the back

**"Hey, what if clients don't want to explore your lil house?**

I wanted the portfolio to accommodate two very different ways of looking at my work. Sometimes, clients visit a portfolio with a specific purpose: a recruiter might have a few minutes to understand my experience, assess my skills, and find relevant projects. Other times, someone might arrive simply curious, with the time and inclination to explore.

Rather than forcing both visitors through the same experience, I designed two ways to enter Ideakutir: Work Mode and Wander Mode(Placeholder names for now).

✓

Source: system32comics via instagram

clienteritis
Noun. (klien-ter-'ietis)
When a client offers a designer unhelpful advice on how to make something "pop"
MEGALOPEDIA

Source: megalopedia via instagram

Work Mode is a direct route. It prioritises legibility, familiar interface patterns, and easy access to project information. Visitors can navigate the house without having to figure out its underlying logic, moving quickly between projects and their corresponding case studies. The house becomes an organising structure, but it doesn't get in the way of the work.

Wander Mode, on the other hand, invites visitors to slow down and explore. Instead of treating the house as a menu, it becomes an environment to move through. Rooms, objects, and unexpected discoveries offer different ways into my practice, allowing visitors to follow their curiosity rather than a predetermined sequence. There is room for play, detours, and details that might be missed on a more direct visit.

The distinction isn't between a serious portfolio and a playful one. Both modes lead into the same body of work; they simply recognise that not everyone arrives with the same intentions. One offers a clear path through the house, while the other leaves the doors open for visitors to find their own way.

When you listen to all of the clients design suggestions...

IDK the source but that's wassup fr gng

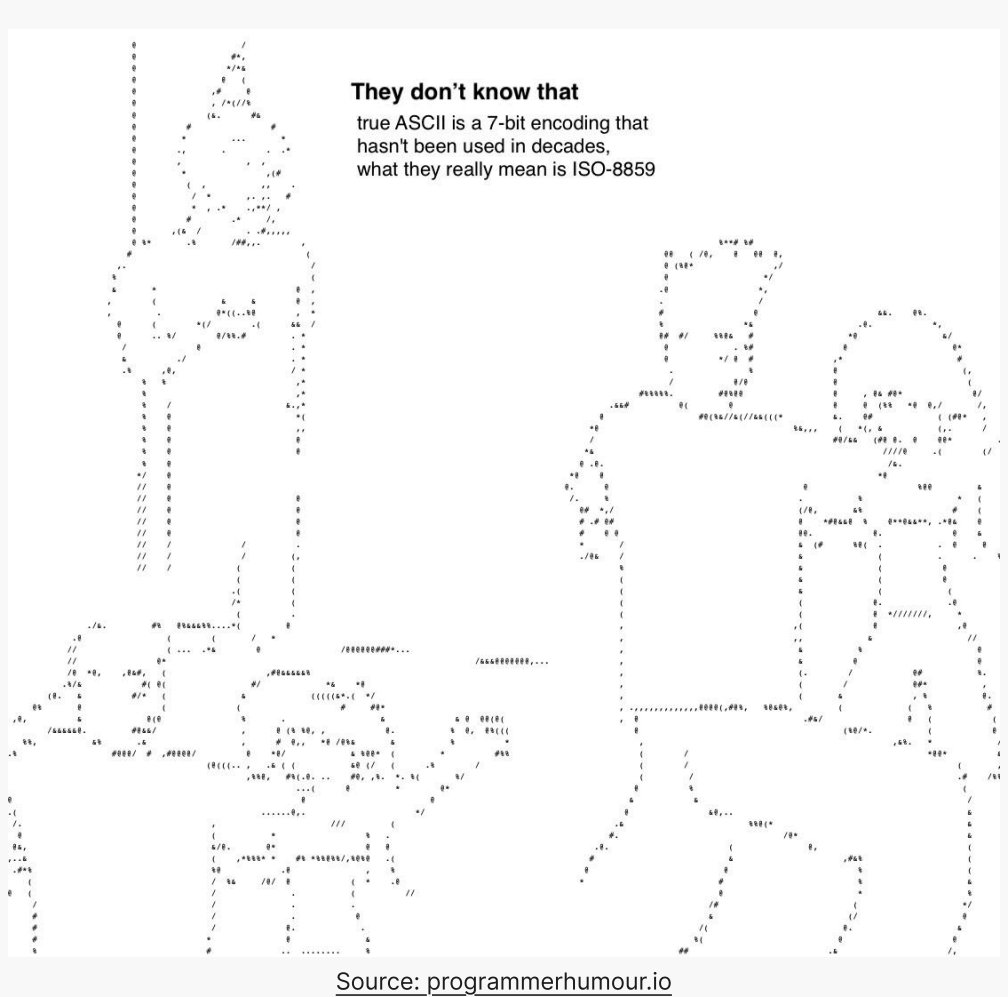
## ideaphoria the builder: Can we fix it?

Source: Pinterest

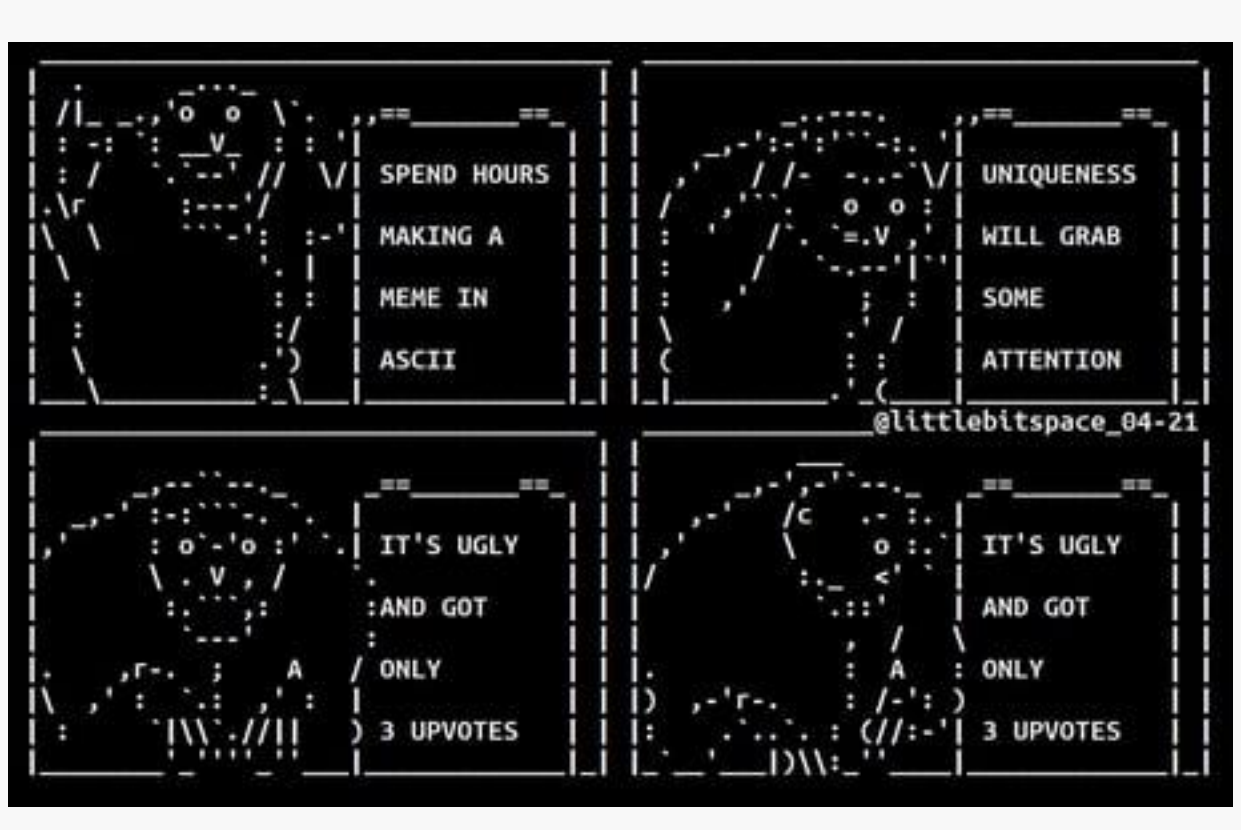
**From a visual metaphor to an actual environment**

Since my core inspiration came from House of Leaves, I wanted to incorporate the use to text characters in a way that shaped the environment. However, I wanted visitors to enter the house, move through it, encounter objects, and discover projects as part of the experience. ASCII art seemed to be the best candidate for this vision.

I built Ideakutir using Antigravity which built it in **Next.js**, **React**, **TypeScript**, and **Three.js**. Next.js provides the web application framework, React handles the interface and its interactive components, TypeScript structures the code, and Three.js powers the real-time 3D environment. Together, these technologies let me bring the portfolio's interface, spatial layout, and narrative into a single experience.


They don't know that
true ASCII is a 7-bit encoding that hasn't been used in decades, what they really mean is ISO-8859

Source: programmerhumour.io


SPEND HOURS MAKING A MEME IN ASCII
UNIQUENESS WILL GRAB SOME ATTENTION
@littlebitspace_04-21
IT'S UGLY AND GOT ONLY 3 UPVOTES
IT'S UGLY AND GOT ONLY 3 UPVOTES

Source: 9gag

I explored public implementations of ASCII rendering for Three.js, including the official Three.js AsciiEffect and GPU-based approaches such as Emil Widlund's THREE.js ASCII Effect on the GPU. These provided useful technical reference points for understanding how a 3D scene can be translated into character-based imagery. The project's own rendering logic lives in **CustomAsciiRenderer.ts**, with **AsciiHouse.tsx** bringing the renderer into the house environment.

I worked with lighting, shading, and environmental elements to make floors, walls, furniture, and architectural details legible. The scene also uses a custom **skyShader.ts**, to contribute to the surrounding atmosphere.

## Yes we can! (with AI, unfortunately)

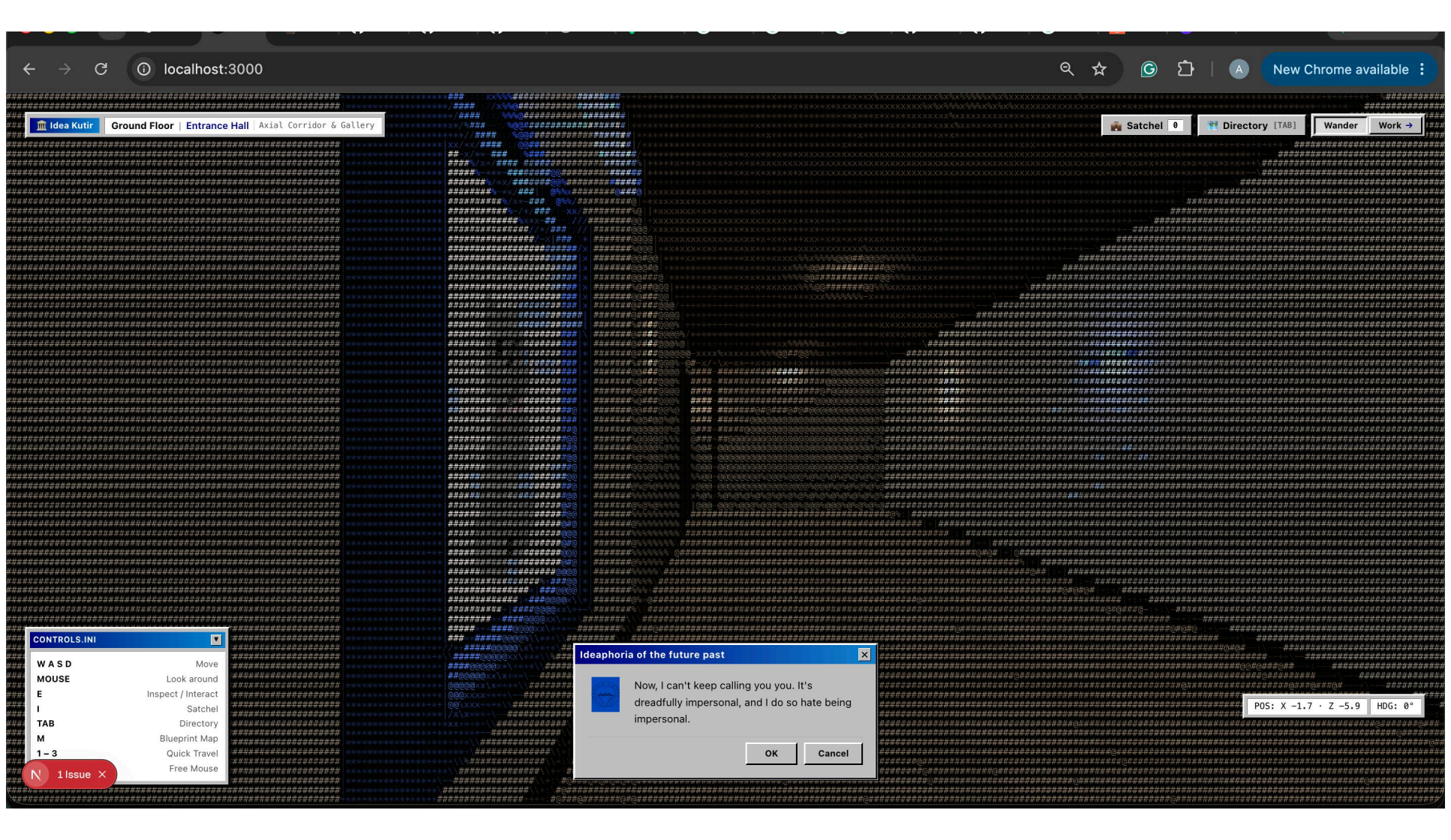
**Building the interface around the environment**

Antigravity had autogenerated some navigational UI without any direction. I realised that I completely neglected the navigational UI structure of the interface. Visitors still need to understand where they are, how to interact with objects, and how to access the work itself.

I paired the 3D environment with a Windows 95-inspired interface, using familiar desktop conventions for dialogue boxes, project windows, and instructions. This comes from my own nostalgia for days spent surfing the internet in the designated "Computer room", the unsupervised internet access shaping my psyche for the foreseeable future.

The two interfaces, work mode & wander mode, create a contrast between two kinds of navigation: moving physically through the house and interacting with conventional interface elements. The former encourages exploration; the latter provides clarity when visitors need to read a case study or move directly to a project.

The underlying structure separates the spatial environment from its content and narrative. This makes it possible to develop the house, its interactive objects, and its dialogue system as connected but distinct parts of the project.sation · Physical and digital artefact



CONTROLS.INI
W A S D Move
MOUSE Look around
E Inspect / Interact
I Satchel
TAB Directory
M Blueprint Map
1 – 3 Quick Travel
Free Mouse

Ideaphoria of the future past
Now, I can't keep calling you you. It's dreadfully impersonal, and I do so hate being impersonal.
OK Cancel

Three.js — AsciiEffect
The official Three.js example demonstrates converting a rendered 3D scene into ASCII characters. View source on GitHub

Emil Widlund — ASCII
A GPU-based ASCII effect for Three.js, using a fragment shader to map a scene to character patterns. Useful as a technical reference for real-time rendering. View repository

## Master of the house

67

macleod
List of words containing "meow": meow, meowed, meowing, meows, homeowner

fingerstriped
this post fucked me up

Trending Source: macleod
63,996 notes

Source: r/tumblr

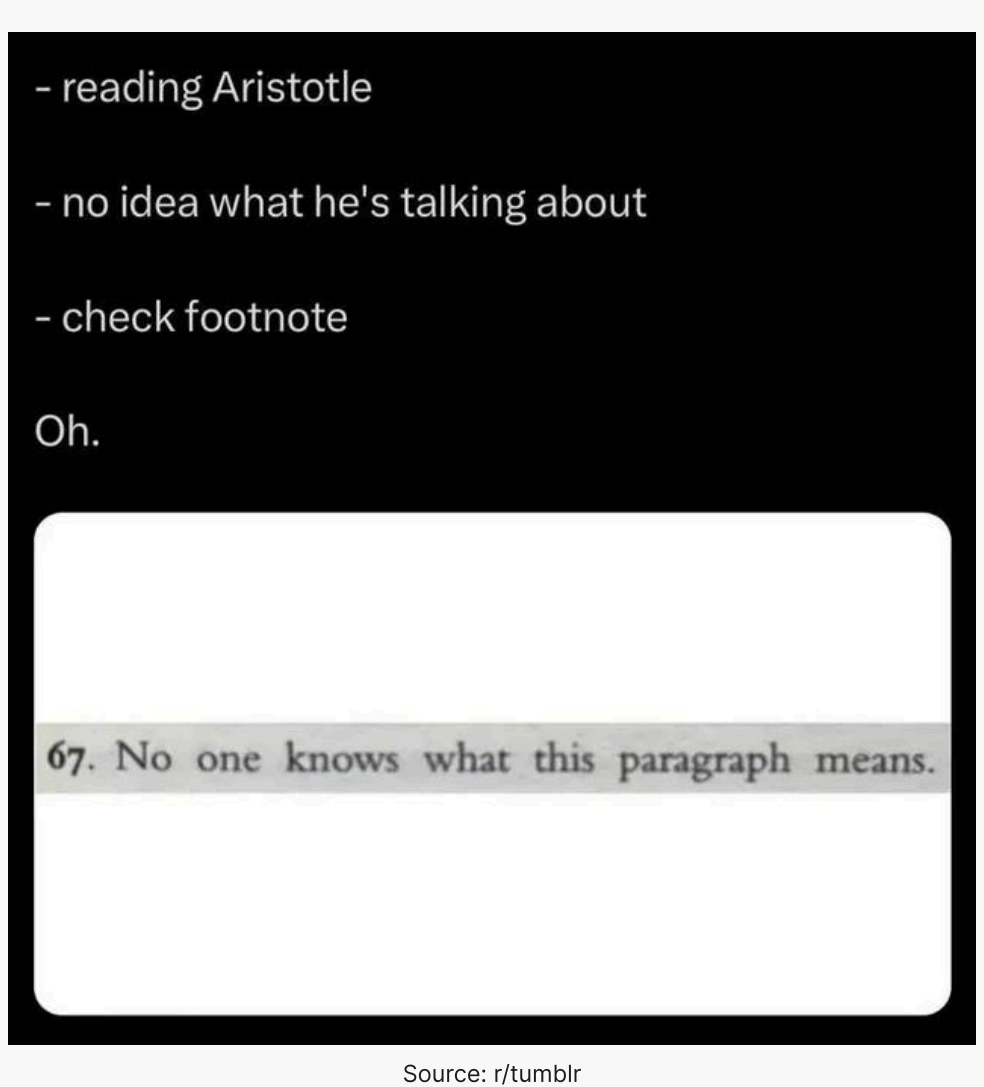
**An inhospitable host**

As the initial few rooms and house layout started taking shape, I started thinking about gamification opportunities for ideakutir.

Inspired from the unreliable narrator of the House of Leaves, I started writing down an unseen host that communicates to the visitors via dialog boxes.

The character is part guide, part gatekeeper, and part commentary on the strange experience of having people navigate your body of work. Rather than presenting a conventional onboarding tutorial, the Master speaks directly to visitors, with a tone that shifts between helpful, impatient, and playfully passive-aggressive.

The dialogue box borrows the familiarity of a retro desktop window, deliberately contrasting with the art style of the ASCII render. The dialogues are custom written by me, so there aren't unlimited conversations. I aimed this character to be a reflection of me when someone is going through my work in front of me: impulsive, snarky, defensive and uncomfortable with the act of being seen.


- reading Aristotle

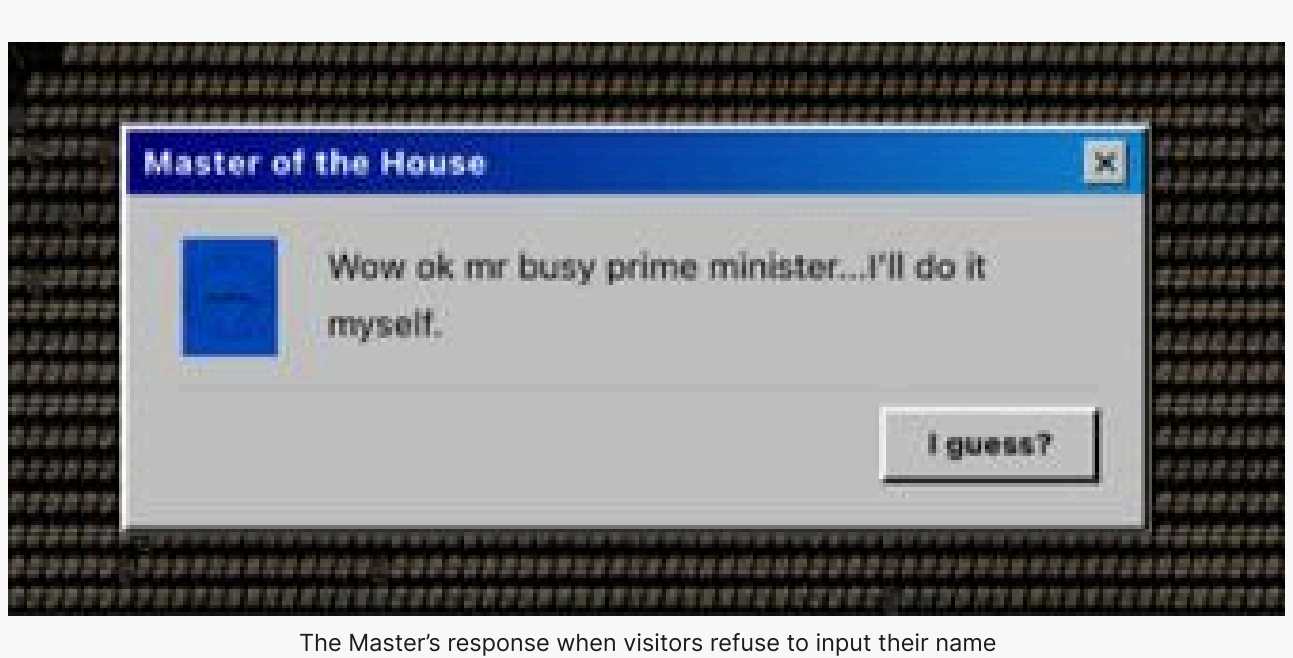
- no idea what he's talking about

- check footnote

Oh.

67. No one knows what this paragraph means.

Source: r/tumblr


Master of the House

Wow ok mr busy prime minister...I'll do it myself.

I guess?

The Master's response when visitors refuse to input their name

The Master of the house is an unreliable narrator, it's humour comes from the Master treating a trivial interaction with disproportionate seriousness. The medium of communication i.e. the dialog box itself becomes a sentient entity within the game play, there are no set CTAs, the Master will provide whatever CTA it deems fit, after the initial introductory flow the box starts to pop up on random location on the screen as well, this helps give more character to the Master.

The Master of the House acts as a bridge between the practical and narrative sides of Ideakutir. The dialogue helps visitors navigate the portfolio, but it also makes the house feel inhabited by something that has its own opinions about the people walking through it, hopefully this adds an extra layer of familiarity in my portfolio, conveying my sense of humour, vocabulary and my habit of easter-egging as a design element.

## Master of the house: Dialogues

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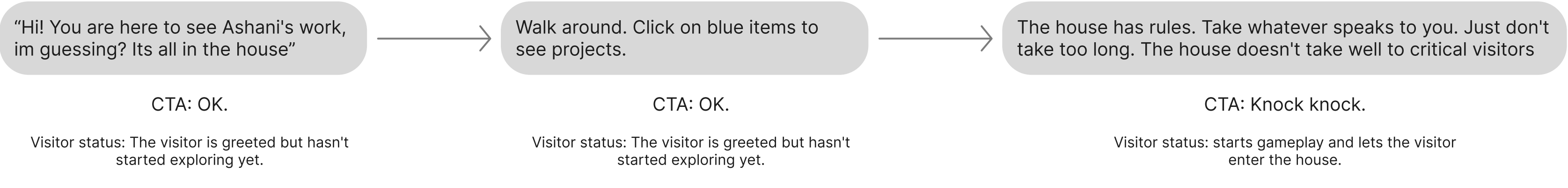
**Introduction:**


"Hi! You are here to see Ashani's work, im guessing? Its all in the house"

CTA: OK.

Visitor status: The visitor is greeted but hasn't started exploring yet.

Walk around. Click on blue items to see projects.

CTA: OK.

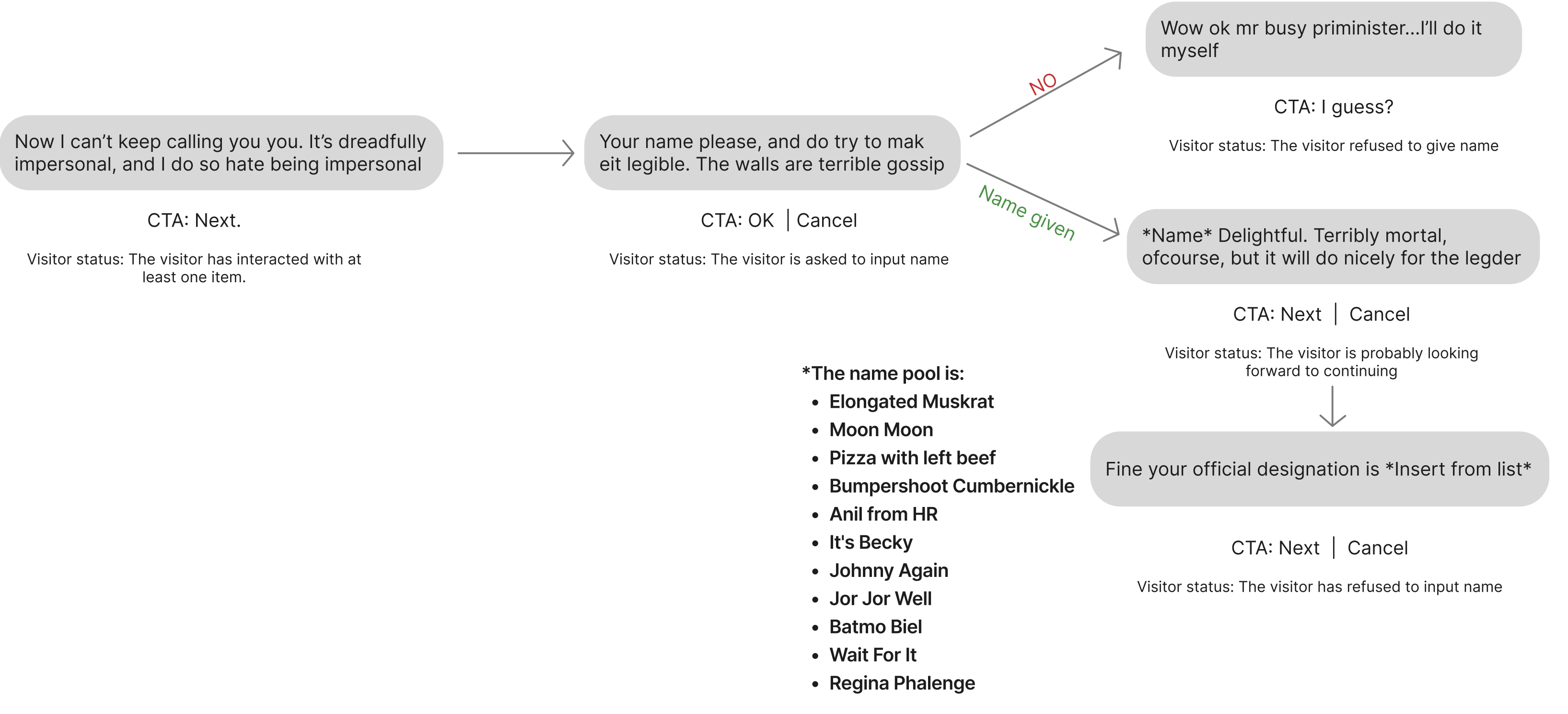
Visitor status: The visitor is greeted but hasn't started exploring yet.

The house has rules. Take whatever speaks to you. Just don't take too long. The house doesn't take well to critical visitors

CTA: Knock knock.

Visitor status: starts gameplay and lets the visitor enter the house.

**Naming conventions**



Now I can't keep calling you you. It's dreadfully impersonal, and I do so hate being impersonal

CTA: Next.

Visitor status: The visitor has interacted with at least one item.

Your name please, and do try to mak eit legible. The walls are terrible gossip

CTA: OK | Cancel

Visitor status: The visitor is asked to input name

Wow ok mr busy priminister...I'll do it myself

CTA: I guess?

Visitor status: The visitor refused to give name

*Name* Delightful. Terribly mortal, ofcourse, but it will do nicely for the legder

CTA: Next | Cancel

Visitor status: The visitor is probably looking forward to continuing

Fine your official designation is *Insert from list*

CTA: Next | Cancel

Visitor status: The visitor has refused to input name

***The name pool is:**
- **Elongated Muskrat**
- **Moon Moon**
- **Pizza with left beef**
- **Bumpershoot Cumbernickle**
- **Anil from HR**
- **It's Becky**
- **Johnny Again**
- **Jor Jor Well**
- **Batmo Biel**
- **Wait For It**
- **Regina Phalenge**

## Future updates

*re: House Tour by Sabrina Carpenter

Source: 9Gag

**Do you want the house tourrr?***

Ideakutir is still a work in progress. I want to push the house beyond being a navigable portfolio and turn it into a more reactive, gamified environment, one that gradually reveals its stranger side the longer someone stays.

The initial experience will remain grounded in a recognisable, lived-in house. But as visitors spend more time exploring, the **architecture will begin to misbehave.** Corridors might stretch, rooms could appear or disappear, doorways might lead somewhere unexpected, and fragments of text could begin floating through the environment. The glitches won't be random visual effects; they'll disrupt the visitor's growing sense of familiarity with the space.

I also want the Master of the House to become more involved in this disruption. **If visitors try to open a project that the Master doesn't want them to see, they might be abruptly teleported out of the house.** Other interactions could trigger unexpected dialogue, hidden rooms, or small discoveries that reward curiosity. The host would become less of a guide and more of **an unreliable gatekeeper**, occasionally deciding what visitors are allowed to experience.

charlottan Follow
your mama so house she is bigger on the inside[1]
[1]Sex

apathetic-theme-song Follow
gaybichon thyrell
#call me the house of leaves the way you'll spend a confusing 5 1/2 minutes inside me
you can't just hide this in the tags

exploration part of the narrative. The house should feel relatively ordinary at first, then gradually become stranger as visitors spend time inside it. Rather than simply browsing a collection of projects, visitors would develop their own relationship with the space, never entirely certain whether they have discovered everything or whether the house has more to reveal. Ultimately, I want Ideakutir to sit somewhere between a portfolio, a walking simulator, and a haunted house game: a space where finding the work is only part of the experience, and where the act of exploring becomes a story in itself.

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### Bablography

1. Meeting, Amanda Tori. "The Pedagogical Power of the A+ Grade: Student Motivation, Creative Confidence, and the Art of Generous Assessment." Journal of Educational Optimism 12, no. 2 (2024): 45-62.
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